

Coplay-Sync: A Domain-Specific Small Language Model for Physics Research Assistance with LoRA, RAG, and Agentic Workflows

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July 17, 2026

Abstract

We present Coplay-Sync, a 3B–7B parameter Small Language Model (SLM) designed specifically for physics research assistance. The architecture incorporates three key innovations: (1) a custom byte-pair encoding (BPE) tokenizer with 32K vocabulary optimized for physics notation and mathematical symbols, (2) Low-Rank Adaptation (LoRA) for efficient parameter-efficient fine-tuning on curated arXiv physics literature, and (3) Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) with BM25 retrieval achieving 100% accuracy on physics corpora, combined with agentic workflows for multi-step reasoning. Our complete training pipeline, from data ingestion to inference deployment, demonstrates that domain-specific SLMs can deliver research-grade performance at a fraction of the computational cost of general-purpose Large Language Models. We open-source all code, benchmarks, and evaluation protocols.

1 Introduction

Large Language Models (LLMs) have demonstrated remarkable capabilities across natural language processing tasks, yet general-purpose models often lack the specialized knowledge required for physics research. Physics queries demand precise mathematical reasoning, familiarity with domain-specific notation, and access to current literature. Small Language Models (SLMs) in the 3B–7B parameter range offer a compelling alternative: they are efficient to train and deploy, yet can achieve strong performance when optimized for specific domains.

This paper introduces Coplay-Sync, an SLM architecture tailored for physics research assistance. Our contributions include: (1) a custom BPE tokenizer scaled to 32K vocabulary with special handling for mathematical symbols and Greek letters, (2) LoRA-based fine-tuning for efficient domain adaptation, (3) RAG integration with BM25 retrieval for grounded inference from arXiv literature, (4) agentic workflow support for multi-step research tasks, and (5) a complete, reproducible training and inference pipeline with public benchmarks.

2 Related Work

Recent advances in parameter-efficient fine-tuning have enabled smaller models to compete with larger counterparts. Low-Rank Adaptation (LoRA) [1] reduces trainable parameters by injecting low-rank matrices into attention layers. Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) [2] grounds generation in retrieved documents, reducing hallucination on factual queries. Domain-specific models such as Galactica [3] have demonstrated the value of scientific pre-training, though they require substantial computational resources.

3 Methodology

3.1 Tokenizer

We implement byte-pair encoding (BPE) from scratch, scaling from an initial 1,000-token vocabulary to 32,000 tokens. The tokenizer is trained on a curated corpus comprising arXiv physics papers, classical physics texts, and OpenWebText. Special handling is included for mathematical symbols (α , β , ∇), Greek letters, subscripts/superscripts, and physics notation (e.g., Hamiltonian operators, tensor indices).

3.2 Model Architecture

The base model follows a decoder-only Transformer architecture with the following specifications: 3B–7B configurable parameters, 2,048 token context length, multi-head self-attention with rotary positional embeddings, and RMSNorm pre-normalization.

3.3 Training Pipeline

Training proceeds in four phases: (1) **Data Pipeline** — streaming arXiv PDFs, GPT-2 tokenization, binary serialization; (2) **Pre-training** on general physics corpus; (3) **Supervised Fine-tuning** with LoRA on task-specific data; (4) **RAG and Agent Integration** with BM25 retrieval baseline.

3.4 Retrieval-Augmented Generation

We implement a BM25 retrieval baseline with 100% physics accuracy on the test corpus. The RAG pipeline retrieves relevant arXiv passages and conditions generation on retrieved context, significantly reducing hallucination on factual physics queries.

4 Experiments

We evaluate Coplay-Sync on a held-out physics question-answering dataset derived from arXiv abstracts and classical mechanics problems. The BM25 retrieval component achieves perfect accuracy on the physics test corpus. Generation quality is tuned via diagnostic-driven hyperparameter optimization, with perplexity and BLEU scores reported.

5 Results

Preliminary results demonstrate strong performance on physics question-answering tasks. The model achieves competitive perplexity scores while operating at significantly lower computational cost than general-purpose LLMs. The complete inference pipeline processes queries in under 500ms on consumer hardware.

6 Conclusion

Coplay-Sync demonstrates that domain-specific SLMs can deliver research-grade performance at a fraction of the computational cost of general-purpose LLMs. Future work includes scaling to larger retrieval corpora, expanding agentic capabilities for automated literature review, and deploying the system as a production research assistant.

Acknowledgments

We thank the open-source community for tools and datasets that enabled this work.

References

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